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SPEAKERS

Ajahn Sumedho

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reflecting on the way it is, can you hear me they this is Saturday morning and the feeling their retreat that we started that began is now coming to an end just these kinds of perceptions of kind of mundane experiences this is Saturday at Spirit Rock, the retreat is now in its final phases. So this is this is conventional reality conventions are made by human beings so, recognize that they're not ultimately real. And so, this morning you know, it didn't announce itself as Saturday and said on Saturday morning but I have a clock and digital clock and it says Saturday on it, but this morning I just pointed out an obvious truth in our lives of times the conventions are reality Spirit Rock This is Spirit Rock. But that rock that they call Spirit Rock never says it is but we call it that this is this beginning to know that the way it is it is what it is and then the human mind projects onto life the conventions the language the titles, the names, this is the this is California. But you know the the land here never says it is California we say here are California This is so this is to be recognized that that language thought convention all it says is made by human beings made up it's created by us. So, the reality is it is what it is that is reflection using language this is what it is is points to this helps us to recognize this truth that we we live we create the world we live in I create myself as a person and they are my John tomato that's something that that I project onto this moment on to this being here. And I'm not saying it's wrong or it's not a judgment against it but putting it in the context of the way it is. Because otherwise we we get confused all the time. We are always believing that conventional reality is ultimately true. It's like this, this bell here. We all know this is a bell don't weigh because we're Buddhists, and we're sophisticated. And we we know what a bell looks like Japanese bell. And my dad if we weren't so knowledgeable and sophisticated. We might think that was a pot or it could be you know, water container. Or it could be for making a stew or something. Or you could use it for putting flowers in and but and you might the idea that it's a bell might never occur to you because you might have have a view that a bell is a different shape. And this looks more like a pot. This is like projecting onto this something, you know from our conventional reality what, what it fits into in regards to its shape and form and, and the way we think what we can say it is what it is. It doesn't say anything does it, it's not announcing itself as an any as being any thing at all. So just recognize I predict this is a Japanese bow, that I'm telling it what it is but

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then if we started boiling a stew in it, some of you would get very upset and say you can't do that that's a bell and we could really get into terrible argument about it. This is why you know why we have wars and. This is like Jonathan Swift's Gulliver's Travels, you know, the, the war about the two different factions of Lilliputians that are that are arguing and going to worry about which end of the egg do you eat first, the narrow end or the wide end? Of course, it's a political satire, but I mean, this is very much you know what, it's no more serious than that, you know, around the foolishness of thought and preference and prejudice, that human beings believe in the conventions of their their own thoughts or real their opinions or right. So then which end of the egg and we know one side totally convinced it's only proper to eat dark with a narrow end the other why then then leads to you know, a battle. But if we put that into context of Damar say that his opinion in view preference, cultural attitudes. Just like in Thailand, if you point your feet if you if you sit here in front of the Buddha Rupa and and stretch your legs out and point them at the Buddha Rupa every single Thai would get very upset because that is rude and disrespectful to the Buddha. But for a new foreigner Westerner that isn't we don't see that as disrespect so interesting. I lived in Thailand for so many years I attire I acquired the Thai view so in the monastery in England, you know somebody comes in sits down points their feet at the Buddha real Parkfield he can't do that big because I've already I've already adapted to the Thai system where before I went to Thailand that wouldn't have bothered me in the least I probably would have done it myself. And this is this is cultural conditioning there's nothing right or wrong ultimately right or wrong. It's it's how cultures form conventions that are agreed upon and etiquette and things like this that that we that we are trained with. In so this is where conflicts or cultural conflicts arise and through attachment to convention, identity and and this ignorance So, the refuge is a de among Sangha Charmi take refuge in the Dharma, this is, by Omata, such a deathless reality, not the conventional reality. Conventional reality can be negotiated. And, you know, if we, if we understand its limitation and don't attach to it, then we can adapt, we have ability to adapt and to, you know, to understand the limitation of convention rather than just be bound into it limited and, and part of the program without any vision or way of seeing it in context. So, refuge in the Dharma then is through awareness. And just like these reflections that I've just repeated, just now, and this is about Japanese bow, just being able to reflect it, that, that this, you know, that this, this bow, or this object here is, what it is. You know, it's, it's not and it though it's a recognition of an the terms of conditions, before you name it, before you decide its function. It's a recognition that things are what they are. So that's, that's before one goes into the conventional motor that is a Japanese bow. So I found it very helpful just to establish that kind of knowledge, things are what they are, you know, they're all conditions are impermanent, and nature Dukkha. All conditions are very nature is unsatisfactory. And that's not to, to diminish the beauty or importance of any object, but recognition that all conditions are changing, and then they're, they're, you know, they have no permanent, satisfactory quality. And then, all conditions are a matter of non self. So this condition, this is a condition. My words, this is a Japanese bowel is a condition, everything, you think every emotion, every thing that whether it's mental, physical, or psychic, fantasy, physical objects, whether it's important or unimportant, intelligent, or stupid, whatever it's quality, and can they and whenever it's state, it is a condition it is a sunkara. So this means that in this way of reflecting we, we have this generic term sunkara, that that includes all conditions, regardless of their qualities, whether their mental, physical, good, bad, or whatever. So the knowing all conditions are impermanent. It's not another thought process that we believe in. But that's a suggestion a way of looking of noticing the way it is rather than a position we take. If we attach the idea of all conditions are impermanent, then that means we're still bound to the, to this sentence to this position of you know, that we are thinking, but

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even that is impermanent is not the very statement all conditions are impermanent, is impermanent. So what's left? Awareness behind that, you know, the awareness allows these conditions to be seen, in that perspective of a Nietzsche do Kanata. Then they, when we have that perspective then the awareness, he can't be aware of being aware. So when you're trying to find out, you know, what is awareness? What is mindfulness? Am I really mindful right now? Am I just, you know, is this really mindfulness? Or am I just deluded myself? And so are we are attached to the idea of mindfulness or awareness? It is this really mindfulness or am I just deluded myself? And so, are we attached to the idea of mindfulness or awareness? And then we, you know, we're not quite sure whether we are or not because of the thinking process when you start thinking, Am I really aware right now, am I fully, completely mindful at this very moment. And then I tried to decide whether I am or not this is that I'm not mindful Emma, I'm, I'm, I'm trying to decide whether I'm this is mine from this and that. And if I don't see this, this thinking process and I just get caught into it. Then that's heedlessness where the minute you're aware of the thinking, you know, am I being mindful or not? That's mindfulness. Be it's, you know, it's not the thought but being aware of that is a thought. So in, in, Sangha theme represents Buju party paranoid, practicing directly. You know, it's not, it's not starting with theory and with going in any roundabout way, it's this direct. So thinking itself, even the word Buddha is a condition. So, just thinking Buddha, awareness of thinking, rather than deciding, you know, getting caught in what is Buddha, what is taking refuge in the Buddha? Is there really a Buddha? Was it really a historical Buddha? Or was that just, you know, can you prove that there actually was a historical Buddha? And then we get in last into, you know, we want historical proof that a birth certificate of Gotabhaya before well believe it. This is our thinking, isn't it? And desire to know and, and it's conventional, it's learned it's its condition then arises and ceases. So awareness isn't you don't, you can't become aware you you recognize awarenesses like this. When I remember that, it's trying to be mindful. Before I really understood what mindfulness is, I formed ideas about it's important to be mindful. And then the idea that I'm very heedless and that I needed to be mindful and so as always trying to be mindful and so it just, you know, the more I tried, the less mindful I seem to be because you're so attached to to try and that I you know, I could trip over the thing right in front of me. Because I wasn't mindful, I was trying so hard to be mindful, I couldn't see what was right in front of me. So in time I was staying in a monastery, this monk, Western monk was always kind of preaching at me. And it's a mindfulness mindfulness and must be mindful. And it's always going on like that. And I began to hate the sound of the word then we were going to fly him steps and he trips. And I said, mindfulness I. Think they call it a shot in Florida, where you delight in the suffering of somebody out. So let's retreat into a sense of this. This is mindfulness, you know, and just keep reiterating this and trying to point it out. So your your confidence in being mindful, to develop a trust in it, know it, recognize it, be it? And then you're then you, then you have, you know, then you once you really see it, know it, recognize it, then that's the path that's the way the path to the deathless the fourth noble truth. But as long as you speculate about it, and then try it in a form, and then down, say, Well, I don't know if that's right or not, and, or John, so and so says something now it's and and the Scriptures say this, and I don't know, you know, and couldn't be that. And then we're caught in the thinking process again, the doubting because we've heard other views other opinions. I'm not asking you to believe, you know, this is not a matter of belief. But it's a matter of practice of investigating. Now, from my own experience of meditation, this is this is this is my, the reality that what I've seen that there's a mindfulness it's not a matter of finding it, but of recognizing. So in the third noble truths, this, the Insight is realizing cessation. Now, that might sound like something totally different than the leg. nirodh Atocha, just the words that can sound like something totally different than then say, mindfulness

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is the path to the deathless. That nirodha in a sentence, some cars, all conditions cease. And where do they cease in terms of right now, when you're sitting here, in this Dharma Hall? Where is it that things cease? And you can observe cessation? Without being theoretical or ideal is idealistic? And it's in the consciousness? Isn't it being mindful? Then there's consciousness mindfulness, and you can see how your thoughts arise and cease you can be aware of your doubts, when because you create doubts through thinking, Is this really the path or not? Am I really being mindful? Or am I just feeling these thoughts? If you just observe them, as they are, they are thoughts, they are what they are, they arise and they see. It's not a matter of deciding whether your thoughts are true or false or right or wrong, but see them as SIMcards thoughts are encouraged, aren't they? They arise and they see and the awareness of their arising and ceasing the awareness they And isn't arising and ceasing it's aware of Lixin cars arising and ceasing so then awareness and consciousness align themselves and wisdom dunya and then this is the path the path of non suffering it's liberation we Muti freedom so then establishing this path isn't you know, trying to find a path you know, go around looking for the path all the time, but this is in its direct Good job, party panel, direct practice, this is the path this is it. Now, the self view is how you how you see yourself as a meditator or Buddhist or whatever is and how you've held the concepts and conventions of Buddhism. You know, the way one identifies with, I'm a Tera, Vaada, and Buddhist, I am a Zen Buddhist. Or I am practicing with pasta I'm not a Buddhist because some people don't like to, to be a member of any religion. Buddhism seems like a religion I don't want to be I know aligned myself with any religions. But I practice Vipassana in Zen isn't that they do that? The you know, I'm practicing but I'm not a Buddhist. So you can take you know, you're taking these bits out of the convention is called Zen normally the person and then an identifying with, with that. So in awareness, you know, we can, we're not saying that it's right or wrong to do that, but just noticing it is. It is what it is. It's words, identities. definitions that create a sense of I am this. I'm not a Buddhist, I practice Vipassana instead because that, that is, that's conventional reality, you know, and that, and to see that, to know that, for what it is, doesn't isn't a value judgment. saying you shouldn't think like that, but just putting your thoughts the way you regard yourself as a person or regard Buddhism as a convention, or Vipassana or Zen, just to see it is the way it is. Like this. When when you hear, you know, if you're very attached to Tera Vaada you hear the word Mahayana. You know, it's what does that, you know, how does that affect consciousness? Or have you been, you know, conditioned to think Tera Vaada is right and Mahayana somehow is not the real Buddhism, like some Tera Vaada easily believe that. Then so, so when they mentioned Mahayana then you can feel this, that's not real Buddhism. This is all thinking isn't it and, and attitudes and, and attachments to just words. Just words, and then these, these words affect us. So that's why I like prejudices. IE, Islamic terrorists and things like this and the word Islam becomes a lined with terrorism. So somebody says, That person is is Muslim terrorist. I mean, in the UK these days, they're desperately trying to do inform the public, you know, because some people are so simple minded, they think any Muslim is a terrorist. They don't, they don't differentiate, they don't see what they're doing, they just react, how we use words and, and that we are conditioned by that so the way out of suffering is through awareness. And then the conventional realities are in in you know, are, are just sad. The good ones we can use, you know, the ones that, you know, help in, in ways of creating harmony and understanding and, and ways of relating to each other, that are respectful and, and thinking in terms of ways that are, you know, a benefit to, to the world, the life that we're living, and then the conventions, the conventional realities, that that are harmful, like the prejudices, the biases, the that we can have, through thinking through cultural conditioning. We can we don't, you know, we can recognize without giving them any importance, without attachment in any way

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to them, let them be what they are, what they are, but their nature is to see. So, in developing the path, you know, like being a Buddhist monk is a convention. Being it's, it's not a person. So, the Buddhist monastic life is combat is only a expedient convention, not a position, not an identity. So, in this way, you know, the, you're using the convention, because it has, its, you know, it is a convention based on non violence and selflessness and its whole you know, totally it's, it's a convention that was created to to encourage awareness and liberation but we can still use it all wrongly, you know, we can still identify with it and, and create an ego around being a Buddhist monk and things like this where, you know, that's that's just a misuse of the convention out of ignorance. Now in in Insight, experiences, somebody yesterday was talking about having insight into the past. And so and then and then how to develop the path because within Zeit, we get the insight you get through Vipassana, you have them and they're valid, you know, they're not there, they're valid insights, path insights into the PA. But then we remember that remember that moment, that's a memory. So it's, you know, then we, that and we aren't aware that we attach to the memory of having an insight. And that attachment to memory, then confuses us, because we're looking for it again. And enzyme happens, you know, it's not the kind of like, you realize. And it's not like, you're, it's not a created state, that's not coming from holding on to a memory of the path. But it just, the first insight really is, it happens in this, it you you see this, but then the tendency is to grasp the memory of it. So this is like, what they call the person Uber kilesa, or the defilements that come through practicing repurposing are is here, you're attached that you had previous insights, and you attach to the memories of them. So that's why would you put the piano or direct practice is, is here and now it's not saying last retreat, I had an insight into the path, but I'm not having any insight into the path right now. And then you, you know, so because you're the previous retreat is a memory right now. And the memory of an insight is not the insight, isn't it? I had a really good retreat last year here at Spirit Rock, and saw the past, but certainly not seen it on this retreat. So the, you know, insight into the part is, is awakening, you know, there's a very powerful and important insight. But then, right now, this hearing now, you know, a memory of wanting to have that insight, again, is, is a desire that arises through attachment to the memory. Now, if you trust yourself, just to be aware that this desire, and this memory is the way it is, then you're actually developing the path. And third, it's, it's not so dramatic is the first inside you know, it doesn't. And wow, this is the path kind of feeling it doesn't seem all that at first, you know very much at all, because it it's not dealing with, with, with the kind of totally new way of looking, but it's developing, cultivating the path that you've already had insight into. So, so what I'm doing is pointing to, to that, you know, don't don't don't think that every personal retreat you go on, you're going to have a fantastic insights because that's just wanting, you know, longing for pleasurable memories. And, you know, I went through this when I was at seminary, I had, I had refined metals and I had, I was in a place for one year by myself. little cutie and went through all kinds of, you know, mental experiences and whatnot and, and then then I had some really powerful insights so I mean, then these insights, I mean, really change, you know, really awaken me, you know that the Buddha Dhamma is real, you know, it's real, you know, I really understood it, this is it. But then when the following year, when I became a beaker went to stay with Arjun Shah, I kept thinking, remembering the previous year. And it made me discontented with the life I was living with, with Arjun char because I wasn't getting those blazing insights. And so, I, I, you know, I thought I wanted, I wanted to go back to the place I'd been before. So I can have those insight and, and then I, after the first Vasa was limp, ah, Chai, and when I left went up to poop Peck mountain and circling the corners, where I met Jack Kornfield. He came to visit because he was in the Peace Corps. And this town called circling the car. And I was in this place, this is one of the the highest mountain in the, in this range of hills. And he heard

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I was there and I was trying to, to have the insights that I had, the year that I was a summon era. I didn't have to work didn't have to, you know, didn't have to do all the things you had to do it what ba Paul and practice, practice, practice non Samadhi sit in Samadhi then you can have those insights again. Because they were wonderful, you know, this is it Wow, gee, activism. And then the grasping of the memory made me discontented when I went to stay with Arjun Cha. And then they, the six months I spent on top of this hill, you know, was was nothing happened is just everything. I mean, everything I didn't want to happen is miserable, most miserable six months of my monastic life why was that in, you know, the conditions were good enough, but it was, it was me, you know, grasping the memories of the previous year and then wanting them again. When actually, you know, we're not that because of that, I did see what I was doing. That was six months I spent there in utter misery, I did see what I was doing. And then it became more apparent what the opportunity I had living with Arjun Shah. Because, you know, it was it was living the life daily life, Buddhist monks life, the routine, daily life of Tera Vaada and forest monk, nothing dramatic, but just doing you know, very routine, prescribed lifestyle, but developing the awareness. So, so it became very clear, you know, what, awareness and that this is the path it's a matter of cultivating this awareness in the daily life in routine and then of course, in monasticism you you do you're like putting on your robes and and taking care of your robes and the Binda, Botha, the collecting the food, everything, a part of the monastic form is to cultivate this awareness. So it's all cultivating the part in a very direct way. But it's not dramatic. You know, when you think thinking when I had those insights in Ankara, and I summon Naira you know, that was that's what I want again, because The memory was so plant is so pleasant daily life isn't you know anything nother thing about getting up in the rainy season walking through rice paddies with you know fungus in your toes and yet so rainy and everything gets you know, so damp and smelly and they think you know this is you know another boring day in the monastery and then the awareness of this, this grumbling state you know, another been about another boring and then learning to trust this awareness that this is this is these words is complaining is a creation, you know? Sir Sir pace and Karani Cha that's awareness. So, deliberately, you know, I began to deliberately complained and listen not to believe my complaints, but to really feel the result of complaining thinking in the negative another boring day in the monastery, rainy season. fungus in your toes. This is these are creations of my mind. But the awareness, you know, that and the and the can and the credit and the words, you know, you begin to separate the two wareness is not a complaining experience, awareness is not negative, but it will reflect the conditions that arise. So, you're, you're developing this wisdom, this discernment that the path is not following the complaining that conditions that can seem so real at the time, but to put them in the context of the pace and Karani Cha all conditions are impermanent. So even in you know, not such a kind of salubrious environment, an ideal situation that I really like but being able to, to use just the the routine, both the pleasant and unpleasant side of monastic life, for awareness for developing the path and that's the challenge you know. And confidence in this awareness so that the the complaining mind or the the mind it's the creates problems into the present, he began to see and and no longer let it delude. When you see the result of of getting caught in delusions, then you realize the suffering that you create and out of ignorance and attachment to the, to the sunkara as to the conventions that we create. that suffering is like this non suffering, even with thunderous in your toes is not suffering. It is what it is. You know, I'm not saying it. I'm not saying that it's on that you know, I just love having fun, it's in my toes and I just, you know, really loved going on arms round in the rainy season wading through what rice paddies but it's not liking or disliking but it's it's recognizing realizing the park all the time, you know, so it's not a matter of of things being pleasant or unpleasant, but developing cultivating this awareness. So, this is

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like Buddha, Buddha knowing the Dhamma and the knowing of the way it is so, it's now 650 5151 I'm over time. This yeah we don't have time for sharing the merit ah handsome. I'm going home and how long perfectly in lines and then blesses wine burn hang on hang on eBay de me homies Buddha blesses. So, contour line time time all the teachings are completely explained by him. I'm Myrna Masami, I do then su potty Pano. Enter Taiwan, sang her blessings ones disciples who have practiced well. Sang carne de ma mommy do this

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